

Neither of Us Will Try to Steer the Other's Vessel

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*You say that you are our Father and I am your son.
We say, We will not be like Father and Son, but like
Brothers.*

*This wampum belt confirms our words. These two rows
will symbolize two paths or two vessels, traveling down
the same river together.*

*One, a birch bark canoe, will be for the Indian People,
their laws, their customs and their ways.*

*The other, a ship, will be for the white people and their
laws, their customs and their ways.*

*We shall each travel the river together, side by side, but
in our boat.*

*Neither of us will make compulsory laws or interfere in
the internal affairs of the other. Neither of us will try to
steer the other's vessel.*

The agreement has been kept by the Iroquois to this date.

*Gus-Wen-Tah or Two-Row Wampum representing the 1692 treaty between
the Haudenosaunee and the Dutch*

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For my final project, I have chosen to depict the Gus-Wen-Tah, or two-row wampum, composed of two parallel rows of purple wampum on a background of white wampum. The two purple rows represented the Aboriginal people and the White people. The two people were meant to co-exist peacefully and to refrain from interfering in one another's affairs. Symbolically, they were a ship and a canoe, sailing side by side on the river, neither steering the other, and both heading in the same direction.

This is a beautiful image, and was a beautiful conception of the kind of relationship that could have developed between Aboriginal nations and the European arrivals. Of course, it is not what actually happened. Over time, the treaty-building and mutual respect that existed in the early days of colonization were replaced by subjugation and attempted assimilation that manifested itself in many forms. The end result is the society we know today, one in which Aboriginal communities have dealt with legacies of marginalization and outright oppression of various kinds, resulting in loss of cultural identity for many, along with disproportionate rates of incarceration and a lack of recognition of their basic cultural rights. However, we are also in an era where the tide seems to be turning, and there seems to be a growing movement for, and momentum of change.

My painting is composed of two panels to be viewed vertically, side by side. The left side panel depicts the ship and the boat from the two-row wampum belt. They are side by side on a river, sailing towards the right. In the colours of the water, one can see the purple and whitish rows of the wampum belt. The ship and canoe are each on one of the purple rows. On the right panel, the river continues, ending in a residential school and a prison. The painting represents the disparity between the original intentions of the treaty-makers for the kind of society they wanted to create, with Aboriginal peoples and White people coexisting in mutual respect, and what actually happened, with just two of the examples of the consequences of the broken system that evolved.

The style of the painting is somewhat simplistic, to allow the symbolism to be more prominent. I have only suggested the presence of people on the canoe, not wanting to co-opt the images of actual Aboriginal individuals. The figures are in purple, like the wampum rows. On the left panel, the tone is bright and sunny, representing respect and hope for the future. On the right panel, the further right one looks, the colours become more muted and eventually grey and oppressive. The river and its banks are replaced by the grey of pavement. The residential school looms above like the schools loomed over communities' lives. Both the residential school and the prison are forms of imprisonment imposed by White culture. They are depicted in grey tones, imitating the colours of newsprint, to signify that the images depict actual events. I have used harsh lines and dark shadows to further add to the sense of oppression.

But underneath the dark tones, one can still see the purple and white of the wampum rows: there is still hope that we will establish a better future, in which the relationship between Aboriginal communities and non-Aboriginal society can be healed.